Content from the Pask Archive: *Details of the Allegory*

Unknown

The Colloquy of Mobiles

Gordon Pask designed the Cybernetic System and is responsible for the two central mobiles. Yolanda Sonnabend designed the three outer mobiles.

The colloquy of mobiles is sponsored by Maurice Hyams and Samsons Electronics.

Mark Dowson and Tony Watts of Systems Research designed the electronics and mechanics of the exhibit respectively.

Several people, including Humphrey Evans, Paul Fluckiger and Tam Murrell also took part in its construction.

The colloquy of mobiles is a social allegory. It has suggested various situations to different people: a parody of the chit chat at a cocktail party or the discourse of some bizarre philosophers; the courting rituals of a strange and stylized animal species. All these are possible interpretations of the work, but none of them is <u>necessary</u>. For the dynamics of the system are greatly abstracted from reality.

The exhibit is a group of individuals (mobiles in fact) that aim for goals. In doing so they must co-operate and communicate and compete with one another. Like any other individuals, they are hidebound by (internally programmed) conventions and they alter their objectives if they are thwarted. But, all in all, they get along as a social group. To a limited extent you can break into the group by adding to and interfering with patterns of communication between the mobiles.

Nothing further <u>needs</u> to be said, but a few details of the allegory may be of general interest. They are given below.

Details of the Allegory

• Each of the two centre mobiles is able to shine a strong light beam, and its goal in life is to have this light beam play upon its black and white receptors.

• Each of the centre mobiles has a level of drive to achieve its goal which is symbolised by the intensity of the light source above it and which increases if the goal is not achieved.

• Neither centre mobile can attain its goal unaided. In order to do so it must co-operate with one of the outer mobiles, for these are provided with reflectors able to direct a light beam onto the black and white receptor surfaces.

• Each outer mobile has the goal of reflecting a light beam onto a receptive surface in a way that satisfies a centre mobile. Each one has a level of drive symbolised by its intensity of illumination.

• Each centre mobile is programmed to search for an outer mobile that will co-operate, unless it is completely satisfied (low drive).

• Each outer mobile is programmed to search in the same way unless it is satisfied (low drive).

• When a centre mobile comes across an outer mobile it “asks” it to co-operate by communicating a flashing signal. An audio-visual interaction takes place and if “agreement” is reached, the pair of mobiles stop rotating and the centre partner spends effort in shining a light beam.

• At this point the outer partner has to discover whether the centre mobile wants the beam reflected on its upper black and white receptors or its lower ones (that is, whether an up or a down reflection gives rise to an audio-visual signal indicating satisfaction).

• To make this discovery, it searches with its reflector.

• When it makes the discovery it learns the response pattern for use on future occasions.

• A satisfactory interaction leads to joint goal achievement and reduces the drive level of both partners. But the process can be broken off incomplete for various reasons (including the fact that the receptive surfaces have a haphazard motion).

• The centre mobiles also compete with one another because they are fixed to the same beam and one of them may want to stop and co-operate when the other does not. The mobile that wins is generally the mobile with the highest level of drive.